

Director or Club? Observed Squad-Construction Patterns of Sporting Directors in Spanish Football

Soccer

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Abstract.

Sporting Directors shape recruitment and squad planning, yet they are unusually difficult to measure. Titles differ across clubs, authority is rarely documented, and public personnel histories are incomplete, so it is easy to mistake a club's squad profile for an executive's personal signature. We therefore ask a narrower question: across documented Spanish top-flight director-seasons, do observable squad-construction patterns differ between directors, and how much of that apparent difference moves with club context rather than the person?

We built a canonical two-layer panel using verified evidence only, without synthetic observations or sample-expanding imputation. The context layer contains 44 director-club-seasons spanning 13 directors, 14 clubs, and seven seasons. The behavioural layer contains 16 director-club-seasons across 10 directors, nine clubs, and three seasons; removing two co-incumbent rows leaves 14 observations across eight directors for director summaries. Before observing results, we fixed four behavioural measures: median squad age, under-23 share, 30-plus share, and top-five value concentration. Three candidate valuation measures were moved to club context after correlations of 0.994-0.998 with squad value. With $N=16$ and six of ten directors observed only once, we deliberately avoid mixed-effects models, clustering, outcome regression, p-values, and rankings, reporting instead descriptive baselines, predeclared Spearman bands, and sensitivity checks.

The observed squads differ substantially. Median age ranges from 22.4 to 28.4 years, under-23 share from 0.17 to 0.55, 30-plus share from 0.11 to 0.31, and top-five value concentration from 0.29 to 0.55. Between-director spread exceeds the median within-director range on all four measures, and this ordering survives the green-only documentation-quality sensitivity. But the strongest single association points back to context: under-23 share rises with the club's within-season squad-value percentile (Spearman $\rho=+0.5355$, $N=16$). Season also matters: the spread of season medians for 30-plus shares is 1.88 times the full-sample IQR.

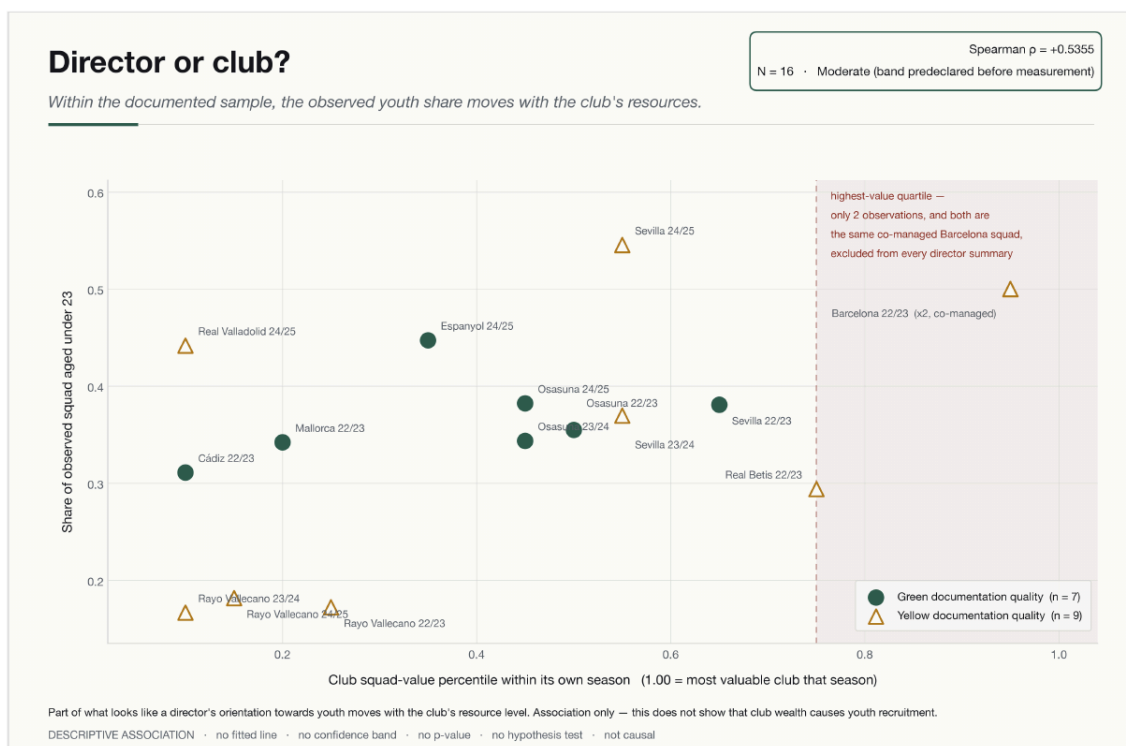


Figure 1. Youth share versus club resource level; descriptive association only, with no fitted line or causal claim.

The sample itself exposes an equally important result. The highest squad-value quartile contributes only two co-managed behavioural observations and zero observations to every director-level summary. Figure 1 shows the youth-share/resource association without a fitted line or causal claim; Figure 2 shows where the director-level evidence disappears entirely. The evidence therefore supports visible differences in documented squad construction, but not intrinsic executive 'styles.' For clubs, the practical standard is to ask how many seasons, clubs, and resource tiers support an apparent signature before treating it as a property of the Sporting Director. The contribution is both substantive and methodological: a reproducible account of what public director-season data can show, what it cannot identify, and where observation limits should constrain executive analytics.

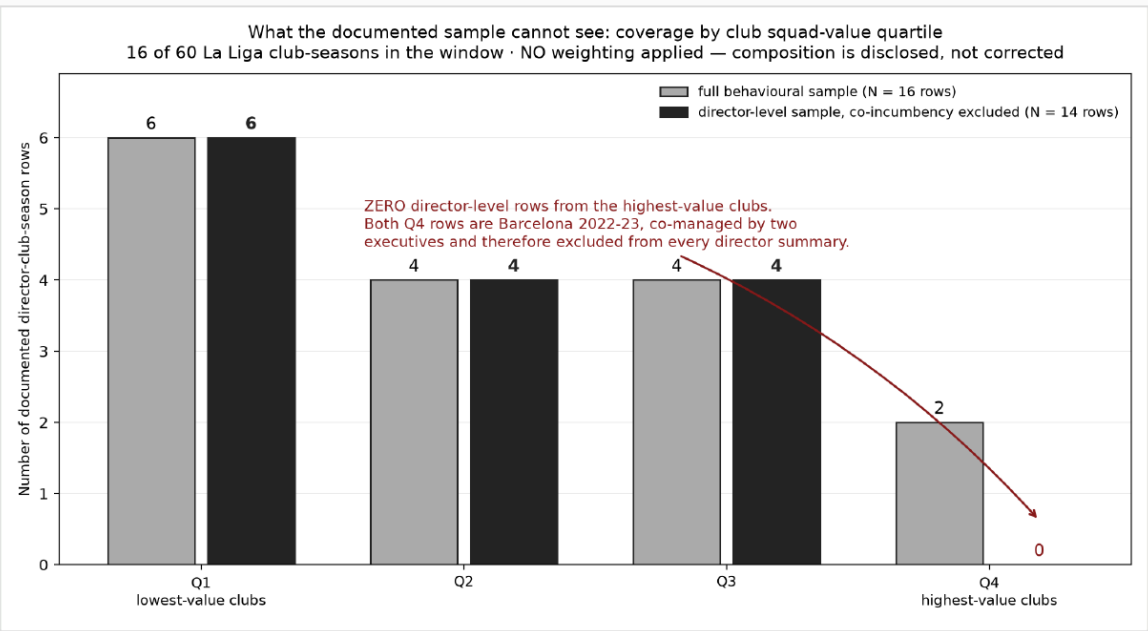


Figure 2. Coverage by club-value quartile; the director-level sample contains zero highest-quartile observations.

This research was developed in collaboration with SoccerSolver. SoccerSolver currently works with more than 10 football clubs.

Open-source repository: [PUBLIC REPOSITORY URL]